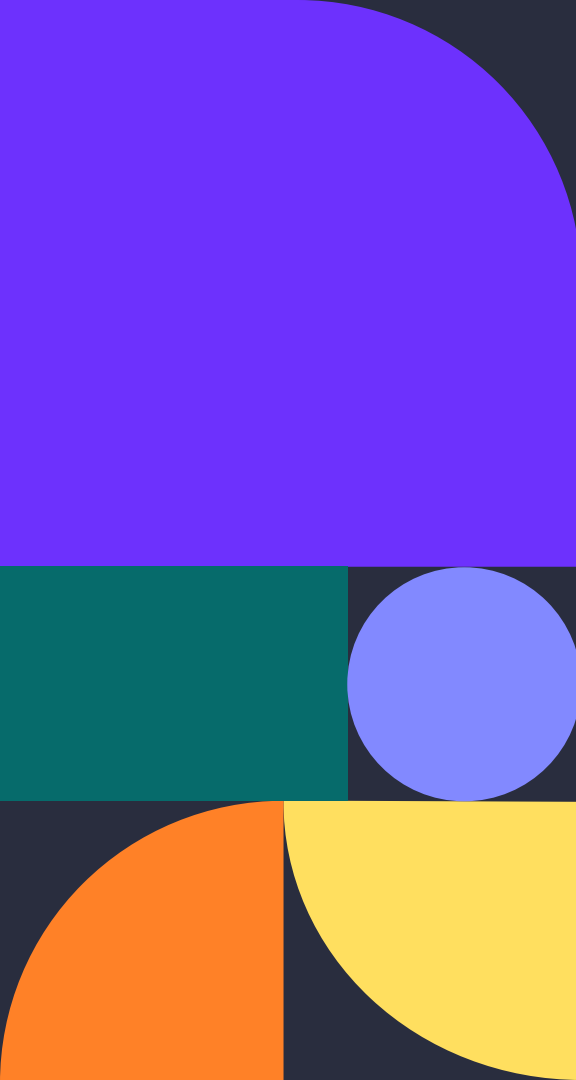




UX Day 3

Usability

Heuristics



Usability Heuristics

The "Rules of Thumb" for Good Design

Created by Jakob Nielsen, the 10 Usability Heuristics are a set of general principles for interaction design. They are not specific rules, but rather guidelines to help identify common usability problems.

Analogy: Think of them as a checklist you can use to inspect your work and catch issues before your users do.



Heuristic #1

Visibility of System Status

Keep Your Users Informed

What it means: The user should always know what is going on, what state the system is in, and receive feedback on their actions.

How to apply it:

- Show a **loading spinner** when something is processing.
- Use a "**success**" **message** after a form is submitted.
- Clearly indicate which navigation link is **currently active**.



Heuristic #2

Match Between System & Real World

Speak the User's Language

What it means: The system should use words, phrases, and concepts familiar to the user, rather than internal jargon. Information should appear in a natural and logical order.

How to apply it:

- Instead of "Error 506: Query Failed," use "**Incorrect Password.**"
- Use a familiar **shopping cart icon** for an e-commerce site.
- Arrange a checkout form in the logical order a person would fill it out.



Heuristic #3

Clearly Mark Your Exits

User's Make Mistakes

What it means: Users often perform actions by mistake. They need a clearly marked "emergency exit" to leave the unwanted action without having to go through an extended process.

How to apply it:

- Support **Undo** and **Redo**.
- Show a clear way to exit, like a **Cancel button**.
- Make sure the exit is **clearly labeled**



Heuristic #4

Consistency and Standards

Don't Make Users Guess

What it means: Users should not have to wonder whether different words, situations, or actions mean the same thing. Follow platform and industry conventions.

How to apply it:

- A button that submits a form should look the same on all pages.
- Place your **logo in the top-left corner** and have it link to the homepage.
- Ensure your **icons** are consistent (e.g., all outlined or all filled).



Heuristic #5

Error Prevention

Prevent Problems Before They Occur

What it means: Good error messages are important, but the best designs carefully prevent problems from occurring in the first place. Either eliminate error-prone conditions, or check for them and present users with a confirmation option before they commit to the action.

How to apply it:

- Prevent high-cost errors first, then little frustrations.
- Avoid slips by providing helpful constraints and good defaults.
- Prevent mistakes by removing memory burdens, supporting undo, and warning your users.



Heuristic #6

Recognition Rather than Recall

Make Things Obvious

What it means: Minimize the user's memory load by making objects, actions, and options visible. The user shouldn't have to remember information from one part of the interface to another.

How to apply it:

- Show **recently viewed items** on an e-commerce site.
- Don't hide important navigation items behind a vague icon; make them **visible menu items**.
- Clearly label form fields instead of having them disappear after the user types.



Heuristic #7

Flexibility and Efficiency of Use

Multiple Paths to the Same Result

What it means: Flexible processes can be carried out in different ways, so that people can pick whichever method works for them.

How to apply it:

- Provide **accelerators** like keyboard shortcuts and touch gestures.
- Provide **personalization** by tailoring content and functionality for individual users.
- Allow for **customization**, so users can make selections about how they want the product to work.



Heuristic #8

Aesthetic and Minimalist Design

Less is More

What it means: Interfaces should not contain information that is irrelevant or rarely needed. Every extra unit of information in an interface competes with the relevant units and diminishes their visibility.

How to apply it:

- Remove any visual elements that don't serve a functional purpose.
- Prioritize the most important content and actions and give them the most visual weight.
- Keep the language clear and concise. **Don't use two words when one will do.**



Heuristic #9

Help Users Recognize, Diagnose, and Recover from Errors

Clearly Indicate Problems and Solutions

What it means: Errors should be expressed in plain language, precisely indicate the problem, and suggest a solution. These messages should be presented with visual treatments that help users recognize them.

How to apply it:

- Use traditional **error-message visuals**, like bold, red text.
- Use clear language, and avoid technical jargon.
- Offer users a solution, like a shortcut that can solve the error immediately.



Heuristic #10

Help and Documentation

Ensure Users Can Complete Their Task

What it means: Help and documentation content should be easy to search and focused on the user's task. Keep it concise, and list concrete steps that need to be carried out.

How to apply it:

- Ensure that the help documentation is easy to search.
- Present documentation at the moment the user may need it.
- List concrete steps to be carried out.

Apply them to your work

Performing a “Heuristic Evaluation”

01. Choose a few key heuristics

02. Go through a common user task

03. Check for heuristic violations

04. Write down and rank any problems



Conclusion



Key Takeaways



Heuristics are a quick and effective way to find major usability problems.



Regularly evaluating your own work with these principles leads to more user-friendly products.



You don't need to be an expert to use them.

Assignment 3

Heuristic Evaluations & Revisions



Purpose



Practice heuristic evaluation using Nielsen's principles



Document improvement opportunities



Apply feedback to improve UX wireframes

Description

Perform the following tasks in your course homework repository

01. **Use the heuristics covered in class to evaluate your wireframes.**
02. **Identify at least 3 issues and propose how to fix them.**
03. **Revise your wireframes and create the final draft in Figma.**
04. **Write a 2–3 sentence description of what you changed and why for each issue. See Assignment sheet for more details.**

Deliverables

- In your GROUP Project Repository, make updates to your branch - LASTNAME-ufw-drafts
- Verify the link to your Figma file (shared link) containing your digital versions of your user flow and wireframes.
- Update / change out your screenshots in your README.md file with your revised wireframes after applying UI UX design principles.

Questions?

Thank you!

